

What One-Stop Service Reveals About Delivery Problem

By Ping Xu

Recent moves toward one-stop service offer a useful contrast for thinking about a persistent American problem: when agencies fail to integrate their own functions, the public is forced to do that work instead.

In recent years, China has moved toward more one-stop government service by consolidating procedures that citizens and businesses would otherwise have to navigate across multiple offices. The point is not to endorse a political system. It is to recognize an administrative principle that should be obvious but often is not: people should not have to serve as the coordination mechanism between fragmented agencies.

That lesson matters in the United States because fragmentation remains one of the most persistent weaknesses in public service delivery.

American public administration is often strong at policy design, funding structures, oversight rules, and legal authority. But those strengths do not automatically produce coherent delivery. A person applying for help does not experience government as an organizational chart. They experience it as a life event: losing a job, surviving a disaster, caring for a family member, getting sick, or trying to keep a household financially afloat. Yet government often answers these integrated needs with separate offices, separate forms, separate documentation rules, separate timelines, and separate digital systems.

This is where delivery failure begins.

The issue is not merely inconvenience. It is a structural cost.

When the burden of integration is pushed onto the public, delays increase, error rates rise, case resolution slows, and more eligible people fall out of the process entirely. In theory, a program may exist. In law, a person may qualify. In practice, the pathway between the two can be so fragmented that formal eligibility no longer guarantees actual access.

The Government Accountability Office's 2025 High-Risk List makes clear how serious this problem has become. GAO again identified dozens of high-risk areas across the federal government and added federal disaster assistance as a new area of concern. That designation was not accidental. Federal disaster recovery is spread across more than 30 federal entities, each with different requirements, timelines, and administrative processes. For disaster survivors, that means the state often appears not as a coordinated support system, but as a maze.

This pattern is not limited to disaster response.

GAO has repeatedly warned about fragmentation, overlap, and duplication across federal programs. Its work in this area has produced hundreds of billions of dollars in financial benefits over time, yet many of the underlying structural problems remain unresolved. That should tell us something important: fragmentation is not a marginal inconvenience inside government. It is one of the central reasons policy underperforms.

The usual public debate often misses this point. When programs fail, the explanation is often framed as insufficient funding, poor political commitment, or weak program design. Those factors do matter. But they are not the whole story. Many breakdowns occur because delivery systems are too splintered to carry out policy smoothly. Administrative burden accumulates across handoffs. Documentation requirements multiply. Digital portals fail to connect to each other. Applicants are asked to prove the same facts again and again to different entities that do not adequately share information.

At that point, the citizen becomes the integration layer.

That is the opposite of what effective public administration should do.

One-stop service is important not because it sounds modern, and not because it makes government look efficient, but because it places the burden of coordination back where it belongs: inside the system itself. A functioning state should absorb complexity on behalf of the public, not export complexity to the public and then call the result participation, compliance, or procedural rigor.

The United States does not need to copy another country's governing model to learn from that principle. This is not an argument about ideology. It is an argument about administrative design.

Public services should be organized around real-life needs, not agency silos.

A person who has lost income may need wage replacement, health coverage, food support, tax relief, and housing stability at the same time. A disaster survivor may need emergency cash, documentation replacement, insurance coordination, rebuilding assistance, and health-related support in one continuous sequence. A family caregiver may encounter health systems, benefits systems, and income-support systems simultaneously. None of these realities fit neatly into bureaucratic compartments. But the government too often behaves as if they should.

That mismatch erodes state capacity.

It also erodes public trust. People do not judge the government only by what it promises. They judge it by whether help can actually be reached without exhaustion, confusion, and repeated failure. A system can be legally compliant, technologically updated, and fully funded on paper while still failing the public at the point of delivery.

That is why one-stop service deserves attention as an administrative concept. It highlights a basic truth that public administration too often forgets: the more fragmented the state becomes, the more costly the government becomes for the people trying to use it.

If the American public administration wants better outcomes, it cannot focus only on policy design and funding levels. It also has to confront delivery architecture. It has to ask whether the system has been designed to move people through moments of need with clarity and continuity, or whether it has merely divided responsibility into so many compartments that no one experiences government as a whole.

The real test of administrative capacity is not whether the government can create programs.

It is whether the government can deliver them without forcing the public to assemble the system by themselves.

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